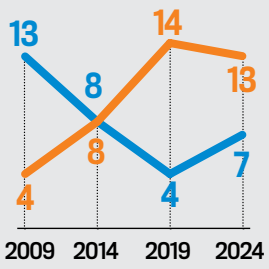
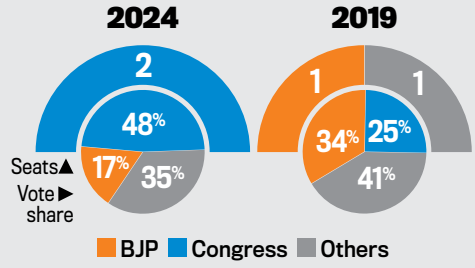
NETTING THE NORTHEAST

How the fortunes of the BJP and Congress have swung in the region's 25 LS seats



MANIPUR BITES BJP

The strife-torn state's three communities seem to have consolidated around the Congress, which has swept both Inner Manipur, dominated by Meiteis, and Outer Manipur, inhabited by Nagas and Kukis



Christians. What makes the win even more significant is the massive surge in the Congress's vote share—from 25 per cent in 2019 to 48 per cent now. The drop in the BJP's vote share—from 34 per cent in 2019 to 17 per cent—shows up in its humiliating defeat.

Manipur is not an outlier. The Congress has also earned a surprising victory in neighbouring Nagaland, the first time in two decades, defeating the ruling National Democratic Progressive Party (NDPP), a partner in the National Democratic Alliance. In Meghalaya too, the Grand Old Party won the Tura seat, the first time since 1998 when P.A. Sangma, father of Chief Minister Conrad Sangma, won as a Congress candidate. Its candidate Saleng Sangma defeated the National People's Party's (NPP) Agatha Sangma, Conrad's sister and head of the NPP. However, the Congress lost traditional bastion Shillong to the newly-formed Voice of the People Party. Barring this reversal, the GOP nearly doubled its tally in the northeast from four in 2019 to seven now.

In fact, the two most defining victories for the Congress came from Assam where it retained its 2019 tally of three. The delimitation exercise had changed the demographic configuration of Barpeta—a seat where Muslim votes offered an edge to either the Congress or the AIUDF—and eliminated the Kaliabor Lok Sabha seat from where Gaurav Gogoi, two-time MP and son of the the late CM Tarun Gogoi, used to contest. Gaurav initially wanted to contest from Nagaon, a safe seat for the Congress due to Muslim dominance. But just days before the polls, Sonia Gandhi asked him to fight from Jorhat. The seat, which includes the Gogoi family's hometown Titabor, had gone to the BJP in the past two Lok Sabha polls.

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma made it a prestige battle, unleashing almost all his cabinet colleagues and using the BJP's massive electoral resources in the campaign. Moreover, several close confidants of Gaurav in the constituency switched sides to the BJP just before the polls. Crippled by a financial crunch and a lack of manpower, he ran a lonely campaign, barring a solitary roadshow with Priyanka Gandhi. This victory—a third consecutive term—against all odds has positioned the 41-year-old as the prime challenger to CM Sarma. Thanks to his fiery speeches in Parliament, a rarity among parliamentarians from Assam, his popularity across demographics and geographies in the state has grown exponentially. The 54 per cent vote share and massive social media followings corroborate this trend.

The other giant-killer was Congress MLA Rakubul Hussain, who took on AIUDF (All India United Democratic Front) chief and three-time MP Badruddin Ajmal in Dhubri. With AIUDF cornering a substantial number of Muslim votes, the Congress had been eating humble pie the past few elections, at times forcing it to shake hands with Ajmal's party. However, with the rapid rise of the BJP and the AIUDF's failure to effectively counter CM Sarma's anti-Muslim narrative, a majority of the Muslim voters consolidated behind the Congress. Rakibul leveraged this sentiment and decimated Ajmal with a margin of more than 1 million votes, cornering 60 per cent of the vote share.

These two Congress victories have somewhat marred the NDA's superlative performance in Assam's 14 Lok Sabha seats—with the BJP winning nine and the allies two seats—adding two more to its 2019 tally. Besides Assam, the BJP has retained its Arunachal Pradesh and Tripura, winning all four seats, or two each, in the two states. That keeps its overall tally in the northeast almost unchanged. ■

Big Winners



Gaurav Gogoi
Congress
Jorhat, Assam

Won with a margin of more than 100,000 votes and 54 per cent vote share



Rakibul Hussain
Congress
Dhubri, Assam

Defeated 3-time MP Ajmal with a margin of 1 million votes, the highest in India